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A CODA ON FLOURISHING FUTURES

Into the Trees

Ann Light

In this coda, I consider what we have brought together and some of the challenges that remain in remaking our worlds with support from carefully designed arts practices.

What Artists Bring

We started the book by saying that creative practitioners bring their own motivation to their work and create it accordingly. This explains the wide variation in the design of transformative arts around us, varying by method, target and outcome and possibly thereby obscuring the crucial generative role they play in society. This diversity is borne out across the many chapters in this collection, even in how authors have given an account of what they do and why. There is no single endpoint to their practice, despite pointing to the potential to dwell together better, and only certain commitments across them. Yet these commitments shine through when assembled – the interest in positive alternatives, speculations that stay local and relevant, the manifestations of care, an emphasis on distributing agency, the embodied processes, where affect and/or immersion take people out of their everyday to return changed and the collective effort and concern for what happens between folk as well as to each. Everyone in these pages is an experienced practitioner, passionate about what they do and interested in where it might lead. The embrace of these approaches speaks to their efficacy; the ambition for them caught in continuing experimentation.

Much of the book has also extolled the importance of gathering, conversing and listening well. We have seen how everyone uses mechanisms to leverage human imagination and discusses the learning to be taken from it, as makers, participants or commentators. The encounters range in how far the intended outcomes

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are open – such as a week of larping in Jane Austen's world (Chapter 7) – or more fixed – such as the pre-determined themes and municipal destinations of *The Strategy Room* (Chapter 9). The tempo of these encounters has varied from the slow embedding of researchers in the lives of Copenhagen residents (Chapter 8) to the rapid exchanges of sustainability-orientated role-playing video games (Chapter 6). And while some chapters have an eye on possible futures, such as the sociodramas sustaining campaigners (Chapter 11) and the coastal workshops that speculate on challenges in the locality (Chapter 13), others are more circumspect about looking ahead such as wolf-masking as an act of intimacy (Chapter 12).

In concluding, I want to consider the point of all this effort. I reflect on the immensity of what is held in our hands, not as responsibility and crisis, but as an act of gratitude for what we already share as humans, standing in this teeming world. People alive today are part of an unusually profound reflexivity, when, from both scientific and intuitive perspectives, we know the fragility of our existence and that of those around us. We sense the perils and hopes of more than eight billion people and unfathomably more other beings. We feel the waves of fate in water, air and changing soil (though it may not be uppermost in our everyday minds). So, I speak here interrelationally, wound tight with other species, to characterise the deep intertwining that is part of what is to be celebrated about living in this richness and take the coda not merely to reflect on the journeying, but also to speak about the wonder.

Capturing the Wonder

Reverence has long been part of human encounters. For instance, the Japanese practice of forest bathing, *Shinrin-yoku*, established in the 1980s for (human) healthcare, builds on traditional respect for place and spirit, using immersion in forest landscapes as a conscious effort to absorb the environment through all senses and offering a lineage from earlier forms of Japanese care for environment. Lack of reverence is also pervasive. With a focus on relaxing and inhaling airborne essential oils released by trees in the world's wellbeing industry, this practice can lose the layered understandings of spirit and relation that it held before its adoption in the West. As the process becomes popular, we might ask how far humans are communing with other life forms in forest bathing and how far they are merely benefiting from the environment that is created by trees (and more) to slow their heart. This is always a concern[1] – how experiences that could promise profound connection become flattened of meaning; turned into consumables; spectacularised; stripped of politics and deeper aesthetics; or in other ways shorn of respect.

But we can write a celebration of connection through the making of these encounters, just as we can shape opportunities for meaningful participation in theatre and art (see Chapters 4, 5 and 9). It is possible to use mechanisms to deepen these interspecies relations and help reveal a sense of life flowing through us and with us. While some people may walk into the arms of a wood or coppice and feel

the interbeing, many of us need a reminder and some help in encountering and processing. This type of creative practice, like others, can be designed for participation, immersion, speculation and justice/care.[2] Yet, it can, as part of the process, ask how we – those humans constrained by human-exceptionalism and our training to view other life forms as beneath us – might come to know ourselves as part of a great kinship,[3] no more exceptional than microbes, hedgehogs or moss.

We have mentioned Furtherfield's interspecies meditation (Chapter 1, reprised in Chapter 13) and roleplay (Chapter 2), which asks humans to sensitise themselves to other species' needs and concerns by enacting them. This was performed in the context of thinking about a park's future: the roleplay was to equip people to consider governance from a greater number of perspectives, not to represent other species' preferences (see also Light, 2024 on this distinction). The mood was joyful and silly, and, nonetheless, people's experiences were memorable and involved a sense of bodies other than their own (Light et al., 2024). In Chapter 12, the forester has been designing and wearing a mask informed by his relationship with wolves. He weeps as he tells of the different quality of connection that he feels with the creatures he knows so well.

The audience for this inner work is often restricted to participants (and then kept intimate), carefully managed to create a safe-enough space for unusual sentiments to come up and linger. Something is needed to lure people out of dissociated lives and professional hiding places.[4] And that might be different for every one of us, as may be our thresholds for experimenting with different ways of thinking and feeling. This is a key reason that the diversity of practices in art and design is valuable, rather than a weakness. It may be possible to change recycling practices through standardised training, but one-size-fits-all approaches will never reach our inner worlds. By way of illustration, the two examples below invite us to discover the range of what might suit us (as leader or participant).

The first is an example of role-played plant life: a ceremony imparting qualities of motherly love, inner wisdom and inner strength to visiting humans. The second is a ritual for celebrating fruit trees, bringing the old custom of wassailing into twenty-first-century life.

The language of plants[5] game was originally held at the exhibition *Unter Pflanzen* in Germany in 2025. The game is described as written (only) by Omipeah Ryding and Roman Schramm (unlike Chapter 12, which was written with wolves), but 'from the authors' perspective, the game was developed in co-creation with Nettle, Oak, Yarrow, and Mugwort' – the four medicinal plants that players encounter (introduction to the game). The authors were, they specify, guided by Ryding's shamanic knowledge: the process of devising included connecting with the plants physically, through drinking teas and tinctures and spending time with them where they grow, and through ceremony, calling in the plant spirits. 'You can see it as an invitation from the plants', they comment (introduction to the game). Participants are asked to request care, receive it and thank the plant, all without words. The outcome is a lesson in communicating through expression and gesture,

as well as in considering how plants, from wildflowers to trees, encounter us. I mention it because it is not only an example of devising with other species, but also practice for participants in listening beyond our own terms and priorities. While I note that the structure invites people to take something of value through participating, the workshop before the exercise and the debrief session afterwards situate the encounter in respect for other beings and share the respectful processes by which it was created.

The second example features Lorna Rees of Gobbledegook Theatre, who leads co-designed celebrations and creates outdoor art featuring the planetary processes around humans, such as a folk ritual for the rock cycle (GEOPHONIC*,* 2021 on[6]) and marking the solstices. These bring people into unusual relations with their world, deliberately inviting a different perspective on living interdependently with other vital systems. It is both ecological and subversive.

A key part of her work in early January is leading the annual preparations for a village to salute its orchards, observed on the weekend nearest the "old twelfth"[7]. Created by the villagers, costumes, headdresses and props inspired by the land and beings around them – deer, barn owls and evergreens – are donned and worn in a ceremony led by a Wassail King and Queen. (And a ceremonial outfit for "Head Apple" was collaboratively made, sewing hundreds of embroidered leaves into a cape.)

Wassailing is an old tradition of asking apple trees to bear a good harvest (Figure 15.1). Rees says the team wanted to make an apple wassailing event to celebrate the orchards' trees, 'but we also wanted to have a party—to wake up the spring in the bleak of midwinter'. The tone of this is caught in instructions for carrying it out:

> We will sing our songs as we pass the Orchards, before settling for our final gathering, with soup, cider and fire.
>
> Just a word of caution–Jane's sheep are in [First] Orchard, so we will be respecting their bedtime and trying not to make too much noise as we pass, just wishing the trees good blessings as we go by in our procession. Phil and Petra will be dousing the roots of the trees with last year's cider so the trees will be getting plenty of love.
>
> NOW, once we are sure we aren't going to wake up the sheep, we will be able to beat the bounds of the land, and to ward off the evil spirits (if you believe in such things) … we will play things LOUDLY (accordion and horn), banging pots and pans in time.
>
> *(pseudonymised excerpt from the Wassail Plan, 2022, from Rees and villager/artist Becky Burchell)*

Both artists have thought about relations of all kinds and created activities that build a respect for life and a depth of feeling into amusements for family and community.

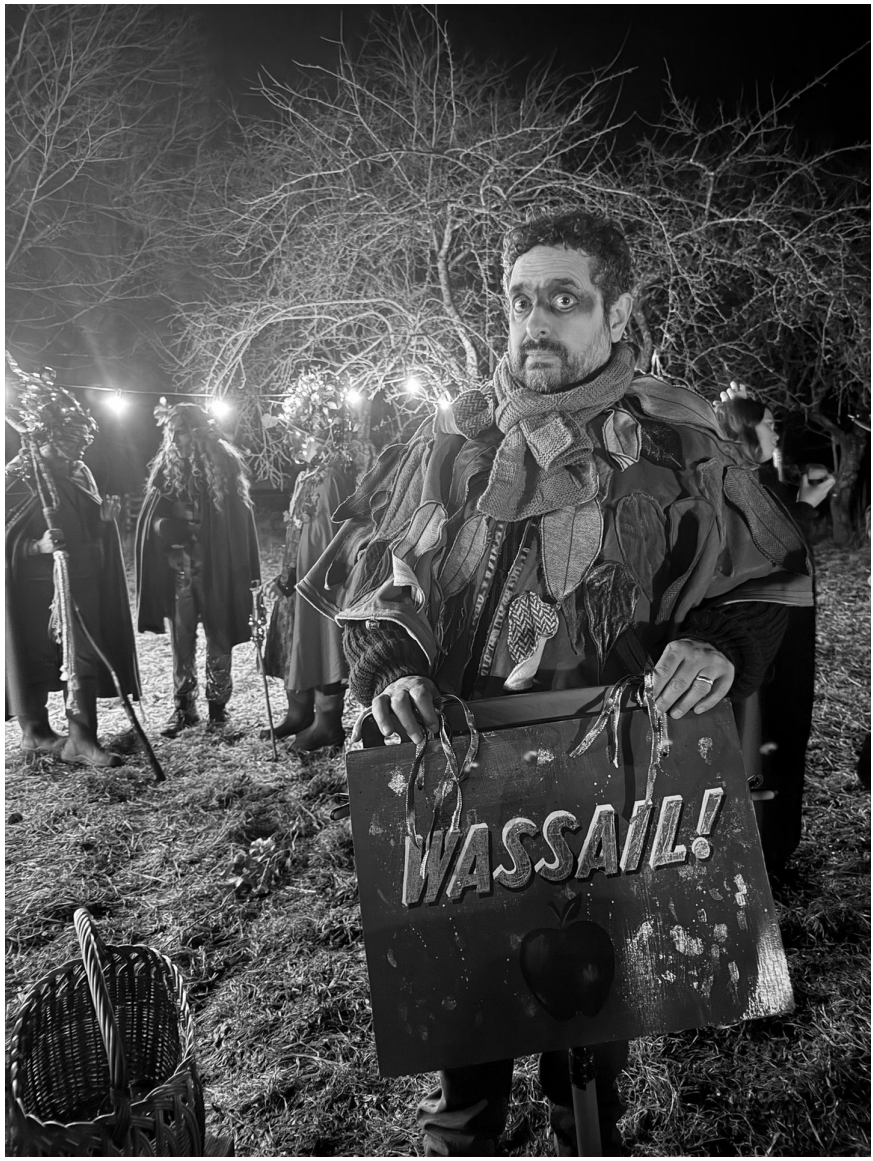


FIGURE 15.1 Celebrating the trees as part of wassailing.

Credit: Lorna Rees, with permission.

The Celebration, the Crisis

Wassailing has caught the imagination in many parts of Britain and event numbers are climbing, including in urban areas.[8] This marks a will to recognise the

interconnected world in a joyous way, while celebrating human community: a fine example of eco-social activity. Yet, at present, while European orchards thrive, British orchards are no longer economic, questioning their future across the country (Hardman, 2026): a fine example of how economics and politics affect more than just the shape of humans' lives.

Trees, left to themselves, have a longer lifespan than humans. Statuesque oaks grow across much of the northern hemisphere, some of whom, watching as their kin became wood for ships, were part of the landscape half a millennium ago. Yews make up some of the oldest living plant life in Europe, dating back 2000 years. Apple trees have a span that easily reaches 100. The many apple trees planted in workers' cottage gardens to feed inhabitants before/during the First World War are now centenarians and more. Many Australian eucalyptus trees are as old as European oaks (though their antiquity is nothing to the unbroken traditions of the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Nations round them, nurturing a living culture of at least 60,000 years). Humans and trees have always had dealings in common. Timber, oil, rubber, nuts, fruit, medicine and resins have come from our husbandry or abuse of trees. Ancient trees have been protected from felling by lore and law, even as axes and chainsaws have changed forests for open landscapes. Trees are inspiring for reasons other than age, but, as a reminder of previous worlds and worlds to come, they are a powerful symbol of temporality beyond our short run, lasting into futures we, personally, will not see, yet for which we act now.[9]

The book opens with a comment about the reflexive quality of our times. It is not that, individually, we are able to choose what humanity will become and do next, but that we are, collectively, at a moment when we see that choices have to be made. With the posturing of superpowers amid the slop of AI, resistance through demonstrating other worlds and ways of being is not only political protest, but shines the light of prefiguration on possible alternatives.

A strong activist anger, joy and determination accompany the work described in this book. That energy is power. The practitioners have given years of thought to how change happens. They work at scales that are meaningful for people's dreams and sense of agency. That is not enough. The governance structures around us need to change; they are not fit for purpose. We act in spite of global narratives of growth, appropriation and extractivism. We can, nonetheless, contribute to new cultural patterns in patches. These might join up, like puddles in a storm. It is not clear when or how. Nonetheless, the flood proposed here is unlikely to make planetary conditions worse, but rather addresses our capacity for fulfilment, dignity, forbearance, solidarity and love.

Johnston (2022) has shown how practices of husbandry in the world before colonialism increased biodiversity as well as supporting human lives. Graeber and Wengrow reveal the many forms of social organisation, subsistence and exchange that allowed societies to manage their resources creatively for millennia (2021). Puig de la Bellacasa has analysed care as a primordial quality of all

relations (2017). Haraway has proposed different kinship models, closer to the idea of collectivities (2016). Machado de Oliveira, deconstructing modernity as a pervasive and dangerous cultural legacy, presents both hospicing (2021) and meta-consequences (Lee & Machado de Oliveira, 2025) to work from. Tsing offers cohabitation and the idea of more-than-human sociality, which helps us understand why all living beings have an agential stake (2013). Humans do not have to be the aggressors we are painted, destroying habitats and reducing the conditions for flourishing. This may be the cumulative outcome of dominion cultures, but we are more mutable than we believe ourselves to be. What we require for our growth, in these degraded contexts, is greater acknowledgement of our interdependencies, more stories of collective care and hopeful outcomes, and finer attunement with the beating life we already hold in ourselves and with others. The approaches in this book are intended to help us find our way towards them, so that we can understand and perform our worlds more gracefully.

Notes

1 This harks back to the section in the introduction about immersive experiences as commercial junkets.
2 Light & Akama (2019) offer a juxtaposition of these terms to show how they support two contrasting orientations to the obligations that we hold for each other and other species.
3 Resources that include creative practices for making such kinship visible can be found in the work of Kincentric Leadership at https://www.kincentricleadership.org/resources
4 In Chapter 2, I confess to an afternoon as *Grass*, which has raised eyebrows. Then again, I admit to building a river out of cardboard in the preface.
5 *The language of plants: A roleplaying game about communicating with plants* was played at the Stockholm Scenarios Festival 2025 and can be found, with gamemaster notes, at https://scenariofestival.se/wp-content/uploads/2025/10/the-language-of-plants_stockholm-scenario-festival.pdf. The German invitation, from Museum Sinclair Haus, Bad Homburg, is at https://www.bad-homburg.de/de/erleben/ausgehen/veranstaltungskalender/die-sprache-der-pflanzen-experimentelles-rollenspiel-larp-mit-roman-schramm~eMl8wEj1Y2L.
6 GEOPHONIC: https://www.gobbledegooktheatre.com/geophonic
7 This is the 12th day after Christmas before dates in the UK were modernised in 1752 to adopt the Gregorian calendar that most of Europe was using, i.e., 17 January.
8 See Tradfolk's list of where to wassail, which is far from complete: https://tradfolk.co/customs/wassailing/where-to-wassail-this-year.
9 The Rights of Trees, Woodlands and Forests toolkit: https://www.sussex.ac.uk/webteam/gateway/file.php?name=rights-of-trees-woodlands-and-forests-toolkit-feb26-v2.pdf&site=21

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